# Manuscript outline: what each paragraph should contain

enceladus_DSM `studies/keff_sintering/manuscript_outline.tex`

2026-10-14, against the Overleaf project uploaded that day

**Framing.** Dry snow metamorphism is the story; the model covers one part of it, sintering by vapor transport, and the bulk conductivity that results, under conditions a laboratory can reach. Enceladus is the motivation and the closing implication. Every claim stays inside the simulated range: $-40$ to $-5\,^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$, air at 1 atm, sealed pores, 50 $\mu$m grains, 30 days, two dimensions.

**How to read this.** Every paragraph of the draft has a numbered entry: its subject, where it is, a one-line overview, and bullets for what I suggest changing. Line numbers (L first–last) are those of the source of 2026-10-14 compiled here (31 pages; the body ends at L492). That upload changed only the Introduction, so the Introduction entries are new from a second full read, and every later entry is the 10-13 review with its line numbers moved up by 16. Each bullet is tagged: **[correct]** a statement that is wrong or unsupported; **[wording]** grammar or wording; **[trim]** text that can go or shrink; **[add]** something missing. A paragraph with no **[correct]** bullet says nothing I found to be wrong. In the Introduction, **[add]** bullets marked **[from the notes]** or "(discussed 10-xx)" are points we have already worked out or that the old Discussion carried, and which the draft does not yet contain. Figure captions are reviewed in their own section, after Section 6. Entries marked "to write" do not exist yet; their bullets are the content. Boxes mark where a figure or table goes. From Section 5.2, paragraph 5, on, the entries keep the earlier form (a "Message" and a content list), since nothing is drafted there.

**First round (user, 2026-10-14).** This round checks that what the draft says is correct, free of typos, not missing a major argument, well ordered and concise. A paragraph that does all that is marked "no changes"; fine polish waits for the second round, after the team has read it.

**The old Discussion is gone from the source.** Its literature points are kept here, marked **[from the notes]** . Their line numbers refer to the PDF of 2026-10-12 in `Literature/`, which still contains that text. Each point is to be checked against its source before use.

**Suggested citations** follow each paragraph, with the key in your `.bib`. Most are the ones the old Discussion used. I have matched them by title only; check each claim against the paper before it goes in.

## Decisions already made, which this plan follows

Collected from the work of 2026-09-08 to 2026-10-12: the session log, the campaign record and the manuscript plan.

- **Framing** (10-08, 10-10). Laboratory-observable sintering by vapor transport, inside the dry-snow-metamorphism story. The Introduction and title stay as written; scope caveats go in the Methods. No timescales for Enceladus temperatures; the timescale map is dropped. Advisor's

comments still to come.

- **Comparisons** (10-08). Not natural snow (angular, more porous, loaded). The analogues are unloaded ice-sphere and ice-powder samples: Molaro et al., Demmenie et al., Choukroun et al. From the snow literature only functional forms carry over, never magnitudes.
- **Kinetics** (09-22, 10-09). $\alpha_c$ constant in temperature; the thin-interface term always on; aggregates stated as $\alpha_c = 1.020 \times 10^{-3}$. No further simulations for this paper.
- **Two-grain argument** (09-09, 10-02, 10-13). Rests on what the vapor route does and does not reproduce, and on exponents; no Thomas or Kingery runs. The two mismatches have different causes and neither is attributed to missing surface diffusion (Appendix, this outline): the rate at $-20\,^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$ is a matter of how fast vapor can be supplied, in an experiment whose driving force is a few millikelvin-equivalent; the exponent at saturation is, on present evidence, an artifact of starting from a pre-made neck (to be confirmed by the tangent-start run). Molaro's conventions: neck *width*, time anchored on the first measurement. The $-20\,^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$ series is the benchmark.
- **Conductivity** (09-23). Tensor law in the interface; the cell problem is a steady problem on a frozen microstructure and says nothing about the transient model. Two dimensions only, so no absolute $k_{\mathrm{eff}}$ is claimed.
- **Clock and normalization** (10-08, 10-12). The clock is $\tau_{\mathrm{sub}}$; curves are normalized at $\theta_r = 30$. The first day depends on the interface parameter, so a "rise from day 1" is never quoted as a property of the ice.
- **Notation** (09-28 to 09-30). $\phi$ phase field, $\varphi$ porosity, $\zeta$ indicator, $\chi$ curvature; subscripts "ice" and "air", not $i$ and $a$; no index notation; a single dot for every contraction; the vector $\mathbf{t}$ named as in Auriault et al.
- **Citations** (09-23). Only work whose setting matches ours; every DOI checked against Crossref.
- **Words.** Desublimation ("deposition" is plume fallout); "vapor"; $\varepsilon$ is the interface parameter, not the interface width.

## Where the draft stands

| Section | State |
|---|---|
| Key points, Abstract, Summary | to write (placeholders) |
| 1 Introduction | second draft (10-14); content missing on snow conductivity and on Enceladus, plus small fixes |
| 2.1–2.3 Model, kinetics, homogenization | written; four definitions to add |
| 2.4, 2.5 Numerics, simulation design | headings only |
| 3 Grain pairs | written; numbers to add, one sentence wrong |
| 4 Aggregates | written; numbers to add, one paragraph to correct |
| 5.1 What vapor transport reproduces | three paragraphs drafted; the first two need revising for what was found on 10-13 |
| 5.2 Temperature as a rescaling of time | one paragraph begun |
| 5.3–5.6, 6 Conclusion | headings only |
| Appendices A, B | headings only; content is in the Appendix of this outline |

**Done since the last check (10-14 upload):** Introduction revised throughout: the everyday examples are in one place, firn aquifers and the circular closing sentence are gone, "Hertz–Knudsen", "densification ... overburden pressures" without temperature gradients, Demmenie et al. announced, the fragment at the end of the last paragraph removed; "Modelling Approach" as the title of Section 2; `fix-cm` in, so the font warnings are gone.

## Work list, in order

1. **Correct Section 5.1 as drafted** (L426–477). Two sentences attribute the shortfall to surface diffusion, which Appendix A rules out; "by 41% and 170%" misstates the numbers; one sentence is unfinished. Details under Section 5.1 below.
2. **Correct Section 3.2** (L330–331): $\alpha_c = 10^{-3}$ is the attachment-limited regime, not a vapor-limited one.
3. **Wait for the tangent-start saturated run** before finalizing what Sections 3.2, 5.1 and Appendix B say about the exponent ("Runs pending" below).
4. **Write Sections 2.4 and 2.5**; move the set-up text out of Sections 3 and 4 into them.
5. **Add the numbers to Section 4** and correct the high-porosity paragraph (L382–400).
6. **Finish 5.2; write 5.3–5.6, the Conclusion, Appendices A and B.** Plans below; the two-page scaling note (`temperature_scaling/`) is the source for 5.2.
7. **Front matter:** key points, abstract, plain-language summary.
8. **Small corrections** (last section of this outline).

## Runs pending

- **Saturated pair from tangent contact** (submitted 2026-10-13; batch file `demmenie_tangent_T-20`). Same grains, interface parameter and kinetics as the run in Figure 4; the grains start just touching. It decides between two readings of the low exponent: the pre-made neck (its shape, and the unknown time it "had been growing") or the interface width. Test: at equal neck widths, compare each run's growth rate with the Gibbs–Thomson value. Expected exponent about 0.28.
- **Molaro −20 °C from tangent contact** (prepared, not submitted). A 10-minute pilot (batch file `molaro_tangent_T-20_pilot`) checks first for a trapped void at the neck, the artifact that led to the pre-made neck in August.
- Until the first is in, write the exponent passages as marked "provisional" below.

## Section titles

The descriptive headings are adopted in the draft. "2 Modelling Approach": AGU uses American spelling, and the draft writes "modeling" elsewhere, so "Modeling". Still to change: "2.2 Gibbs-Thomson Condition" (Interface Kinetics and the Sintering Time Scale), "2.3 Homogenizing for Effective Thermal Conductivity" (Effective Thermal Conductivity by Homogenization), and capitals in "5.1 What vapor transport alone reproduces". All optional.

## Build check (LaTeX warnings)

The project uploaded on 2026-10-14 compiles here in 31 pages with **no warnings at all**: no overfull or underfull boxes, no undefined citations or references, no font substitutions (the `fix-cm` line worked), and BibTeX reports none. What remains:

1. **"Label(s) may have changed. Rerun"** appears after any edit that moves a label and goes away on the next compile. Overleaf reruns automatically; if it persists there, recompile from scratch (the "Recompile" menu, "Clear cached files").
2. **Not cited in the text** (no warning, but AGU requires it): Table 2 (temperature-dependent quantities), Table 3 (complete parameters), Figure 2.
3. **Unused files** in the project: the Figure 8 timescale map, the all-porosity variant of Figure 7, and the AGU template file.

If Overleaf shows warnings other than these, paste them: its compiler settings can differ from the build here.

## Front matter

1. **Title and authors** (L1–4)

   *The paper's name and author list.*

   - [wording] "Modeling The Impact": lower-case "the". Remove "–Version 2".

- [wording] "Ahmed, Mahjoub": stray comma inside one author's name.

2. **Key points** (L7–8, placeholder)

   *Three statements of at most 140 characters each.*

   - [add] For a given ice-grain packing, temperature from $-40$ to $-5\,^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$ only rescales the time over which sintering raises conductivity.
   - [add] Effective conductivity follows specific surface area by one power law in well-connected packings; porosity sets its level.
   - [add] Vapor transport alone reproduces part of the neck growth measured between ice grains in the laboratory.

3. **Abstract** (L9–31, marked "needs to be updated")

   *Background, method, the two-grain test, the aggregate result.*

   - [correct] "Driven by temperature gradients": every run here is isothermal.
   - [correct] "replicating experimental results for various temperatures without retuning" and "incorporating a temperature dependence into our kinetic parameters measured in experiments": neither is done; $\alpha_c$ is constant and the model gives 41% of the measured growth.
   - [correct] "collapse ... for both varying temperatures and varying porosities": across temperature yes; across porosity only the exponent is shared, for $\varphi \leq 0.375$.
   - [trim] The first five sentences are background; keep two.
   - [add] Sentence by sentence: setting; gap (conductivity as grains sinter without compaction); method; grain pairs (41% at $-20\,^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$; exponent at saturation); aggregates (125 runs); result 1 (same conductivity against SSA at every temperature within 0.3%); result 2 ($\mathrm{SSA}^{-0.80}$ for $\varphi \leq 0.375$, level set by porosity); meaning. At most 250 words (it is 254 now).

4. **Plain Language Summary** (L32–55, marked "needs to be updated")

   *The same story for a general reader.*

   - [correct] "tune our model at $-20\,^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$ ... without retuning ... strong agreement" and "regardless of temperature or initial porosity": as for the abstract.
   - [correct] "changes in temperatures (sunrise or sunset)" and "gradients in temperature": not part of this study.
   - [wording] "know as" (known); "effecting", "effects" twice, "effect" (affecting, affects, affect); "C.Then" (space).
   - [trim] About 300 words; the limit is 200.

# 1 Introduction

Kept as drafted in structure; no reordering. Second read, 2026-10-14 source. Eight paragraphs; the two [add] items with most weight are paragraph 3 (why conductivity matters on Enceladus) and paragraph 7 (what is already known about snow conductivity), because the paper's main result is a conductivity law and the Introduction does not yet review any conductivity work.

1. **What dry snow metamorphism is** (L57–66)

   *Defines the process and says it changes connectivity and bulk properties.*

- No changes (first round, 2026-10-14). Porosity stays in the list: metamorphism in general does change it, and the reader expects it; the model section says the model has only a non-densifying mechanism, so porosity is constant there ("Scope", Section 2.1). The driving-force sentence is right as written: curvature differences set up the vapor gradients that carry mass, and temperature gradients add to them. "Topological" is right for sintering, which joins grains through necks and pinches pores off. Freeze/melt stays: the paragraph is about how ice changes in general, not only by sintering.

2. **Why it matters on Earth** (L67–78)

   *Everyday examples, avalanches, and heat flow through snowpacks.*

   - **[wording]** "DSM is the reason why": "DSM is why". "viability of ice in our alpine and polar regions": "persistence of ice in alpine and polar regions". "understanding for how": "understanding of how".
   - **[wording]** "glacial systems": metamorphism acts in the snow and firn on a glacier, not in glacier ice; "snowpacks and firn".
   - **[correct]** The permafrost clause goes (user, 10-14): unsupported by Calonne et al. (2011) and outside the paper's scope.
   - **[add]** In its place, why bulk conductivity matters for large icy systems, e.g. "The effective thermal conductivity of snow, firn and porous ice sets how fast heat crosses them and so the temperature profile within them (Calonne et al., 2011, 2019), and it is an input of the detailed snowpack models used to follow their evolution (Lehning et al., 2002; Vionnet et al., 2012)." All four are in the `.bib`; check each claim against the paper.

3. **Icy bodies and Enceladus** (L79–95)

   *Water ice in the solar system, the plume, and where sintering is expected.*

   - **[wording]** "warm enough cause in significant sintering": "warm enough to cause significant sintering". "near Tiger Stripes": "near the Tiger Stripes". "Cassini, which observed numerous jets" follows "observed directly": use "detected" once. "Europa and Enceladus are": comma after Enceladus. "of plume deposit": "of the plume deposit".
   - **[wording]** "Throughout our solar system various bodies have or are presumed to have": "Many bodies in the solar system have, or are thought to have, . . . ".
   - **[correct]** "Much of Enceladus' surface experiences conditions that cause little to no sintering resulting in unconsolidated granular packings" (checked against both PDFs in `Literature/`, 10-14). Choukroun et al. support it: "Under typical Enceladus surface conditions, little to no strengthening is expected for plume deposits"; in the south polar region (mean below 50 K) reaching 1 MPa takes at least the age of the solar system, at equatorial noon ($> 80$ K) about 100 Myr, and deposits stay "poorly consolidated". Their measure is strength (cone penetration), and they say "poorly consolidated", not "unconsolidated". Molaro et al. do not support it: at 80 K they give a sintering time of about $10^3$ yr for a 0.1 $\mu$m plume grain (their Section 5.4), short against the surface age. Cite Choukroun et al. alone, and say "little to no strengthening . . . poorly consolidated". The 180 K sentence is supported: Choukroun et al. cite Spencer & Nimmo (2013) for it and give about 10 MPa ("very consolidated") in about 15 years.
   - **[add]** **Why conductivity matters there** (the paragraph says it will change but not why anyone needs it). **[from the notes]** Byrne et al. (2024): an insulating near-surface layer controls the subsurface temperature, and so the radar attenuation that a future sounder

would see; conductivity of that layer is one of their key inputs. One sentence, citing `byrneRadarAttenuationSubsurface2024`.

- [add] **Competing rates near the fractures.** [from the notes] Choukroun et al.: fallout of 0.01–1 mm $\mathrm{yr}^{-1}$ near the Tiger Stripes, so a deposit is buried while it sinters. One clause; it is why the rate of sintering, not only its end state, matters. (Checked: Choukroun et al. give 0.01–1 mm $\mathrm{yr}^{-1}$, citing Kempf et al., 2010 and Southworth et al., 2019.)
- [add] **Observed grain-size pattern.** [from the notes] Jaumann et al. (2008): grains coarsen toward the fractures in VIMS data, which they attribute to the deposit's history. Optional; cite only if the claim matches their text (`jaumannDistribution IcyParticles2008`).
- [add] "increasing mechanical strength": give Choukroun et al.'s result in one clause (penetration resistance grows roughly linearly in time, activation energy $24.3 \pm 3.3$ kJ $\mathrm{mol}^{-1}$; checked). It also sets up paragraph 4 (below).

4. **Sintering as part of metamorphism** (L96–107)

*Neck growth between grains, which transport route dominates, earlier work.*

- [correct] "Other modes of diffusion tend to have limited effects ... (Molaro et al., 2019; Choukroun et al., 2020)": Choukroun et al. interpret their activation energy as close to that of surface self-diffusion, so they are not a source for vapor dominance. Cite Molaro et al. alone, and say "for necks larger than a few micrometres" (their own rates; Appendix A of this outline).
- [correct] "as shown in figure 1": Figure 1 and its caption show surface diffusion and vapor transport as equal partners; the text now says vapor dominates. Either the caption says "the two routes" without ranking them, or the text says Figure 1 shows both routes and the model contains only vapor transport.
- [wording] "The initial stage in DSM is sintering": "In a granular deposit, the first stage of DSM is sintering". "The dominating mode of diffusion tends to be vapor diffusion": "Mass moves mainly by vapor diffusion". "figure 1": `\Cref` at the start of a clause gives "Figure 1"; mid-sentence AGU also capitalizes it.
- [correct] The examples of sintering work (Flin, Colbeck 1980/1983) are snow metamorphism, not sintering of grain pairs. The sintering literature proper is missing: see the next bullet.
- [add] **Classical sintering and its exponents** (discussed 10-02, 10-09; "exponents only"). Neck growth follows $w \propto t^n$, and $n$ identifies the route: 1/3 for evaporation–condensation, smaller exponents (1/5, 1/7) for volume and surface diffusion (Kuczynski, 1949; Kingery & Berg, 1955; for ice, Hobbs & Mason, 1964). The paper uses exactly this in Section 3.2, and Figure 4 plots a $t^{1/3}$ curve, which Section 3.2 attributes to Demmenie et al. (2025). The classical sources are not in the `.bib`; one of them, next to Demmenie et al., tells the reader the 1/3 is the standard vapor-transport result and not only theirs. (Check the exponents against the papers when adding them.)
- [add] **What Molaro et al. measured.** The paragraph describes their model but not their experiment, which is the one this paper reproduces: neck growth between ice spheres on a cold stage at −20 and −5 °C, with an exponent of $0.23 \pm 0.03$ at −20 °C against their model's 0.13 (Section 3; `studies/molaro_2019/exponents`).
- [add] **Demmenie et al. (2025)** has left this paragraph and appears only in paragraph 8. Add one sentence on what they measured ("Ice Sintering by Sublimation and Condensation":

neck growth between ice spheres, and the exponent they report), since Section 3.2 compares with it.

**Figure 1** [written] placed. Caption: see "Figure captions" after Section 6.

5. **Attachment kinetics** (L108–124)

   *Supersaturation, the Hertz–Knudsen law, and the condensation coefficient.*

   - [correct] "Libbrecht (2017) led an experiment in near vacuum": still the review. The measurements are Libbrecht & Rickerby (2013), `libbrechtMeasurements SurfaceAttachment2013`. "in near vacuum … within a vacuum": once.
   - [correct] "Other studies have bounded the condensation coefficient $\alpha_c \in [10^{-3}, 10^{-1}]$": needs citations. [from the notes] Kaempfer & Plapp (2009) and Libbrecht & Rickerby (2013) used this range; Braun et al. (2024) back out values across it. Missing space before "Fully".
   - [correct] "Vapor molecules do not always nucleate on icy surfaces due to their hexagonal crystallographic structure": nucleation is of new molecular layers on facets, not of molecules. "On a faceted surface a new molecular layer must nucleate before it can grow, which slows attachment; the condensation coefficient expresses this."
   - [add] Give the form: in the layer-nucleation picture $\alpha_c = \exp(-\sigma_0/\sigma)$, so $\alpha_c$ depends on the supersaturation as well as on temperature. That is what "saturation dependencies" in the last sentence refers to, and a reader needs it to see why a constant $\alpha_c$ is an approximation (discussed 09-22).
   - [add] End on what this paper does: $\alpha_c$ is held constant in each study ($10^{-3}$ in the aggregates, 0.1 for Molaro's experiments) and treated as an effective parameter (Section 5.1). Without this the paragraph promises a temperature-dependent $\alpha_c$ that the paper does not have.
   - [wording] "Ice growth from vapor transport will occur in response to its environmental conditions, governed by": "The growth rate of ice from vapor depends on". "super saturation": one word. Two spaces and a stray space around $v_{\mathrm{kin}}$ and $\sigma_{\mathrm{surf}}$ in the source.
   - [add] (optional) Which limit applies depends on $\alpha_c$ and grain size: with $\alpha_c = 10^{-3}$ and 50 $\mu$m grains, attachment and diffusion resistances are comparable ($\Lambda \approx 2.8$, scaling note). Better placed in Section 2.2 or 5.2; mention here only if it helps paragraph 8.

6. **Metamorphism beyond a pair; earlier models** (L125–141)

   *From a grain pair to an aggregate, and the models that exist.*

   - [correct] **Moure & Fu (2024) is a wet-snow model** ("A Phase-Field Model for Wet Snow Metamorphism"). Here it is cited among efforts on DSM, and paragraph 8 calls it a model "that simulates DSM". Say this paper uses its two-phase (ice–air) form, as Section 5 already does ("the two-phase equivalent").
   - [correct] "In both these works, it was required to tune": three models precede it. Name them: "Bouvet et al. and Braun et al. both tuned …".
   - [add] The numbers that make the point. [from the notes] Bouvet et al. (2022) fitted $\alpha_c = (9.8 \pm 0.7) \times 10^{-4}$ to an experiment at $-2\,^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$; Braun et al. (2024) found values from $10^{-3}$ to $10^{-1}$ that change as surfaces facet. This is the evidence that $\alpha_c$ is an effective, setting-dependent parameter.
   - [add] Isothermal metamorphism has been observed directly: Kaempfer & Schneebeli (2007) and Löwe et al. (2011) followed SSA falling with time at constant temperature in tomography

(`kaempferObservationIsothermalMetamorphism2007`; Löwe is already cited here). They are the closest experimental analogues to the aggregate runs; one sentence saying so. Check the claims against the papers.

- [wording] "all stages DSM": "all stages of DSM". "in hopes better predict": "to better predict". "were the first to attempt to use": "were the first to use". "the icy porous media will eventually begin to undergo": "icy porous media eventually densify". "steady state" (adjective): "steady-state".
- [trim] "This is a problem with complex dynamics ... alike" and "Numerous models have been used ..." carry no information; the named models that follow make the point.
- [trim] Libbrecht (2017) in the list of DSM studies: it is crystal growth, not metamorphism, and is cited in paragraph 5 already.

7. **What is not known** (L142–149)

   *The gap the paper addresses.*

   - [correct] "How metamorphism influences the macroscopic properties in the absence of compaction is still unquantified": still too strong. Schneebeli & Sokratov (2004) and Calonne et al. (2014) followed conductivity at constant density under a temperature gradient (both in the `.bib`). What is not quantified is the isothermal case: sintering alone, at fixed porosity.
   - [correct] The last sentence (more work needed on kinetics, temperature and humidity) ends the gap paragraph on a gap this paper does not close. End instead on the paper's gap: how conductivity follows the microstructure during isothermal sintering, and whether temperature and porosity change that relation.
   - [add] **What is known about snow conductivity** (the main missing content; in the old Discussion notes, L507–529). [from the notes] Calonne et al. (2011): full conductivity tensor from tomography of 30 snow samples by homogenization; a regression on density, with the scatter attributed to anisotropy. Calonne et al. (2014): under a gradient, conductivity changed at constant density, with SSA and anisotropy, so density alone does not determine it. Schneebeli & Sokratov (2004): the same observation. Two or three sentences; this is what makes "conductivity against SSA" the natural question.
   - [add] **Why SSA** (discussed 10-08; [from the notes] old L562–568). SSA is measured in the field and laboratory (Matzl & Schneebeli, 2006; Gallet et al., 2009; Proksch et al., 2015; all in the `.bib`), so a law in SSA can be applied. One sentence.
   - [add] **What the conductivity here includes.** [from the notes] Fourteau et al. (2021) show that vapor transport under a gradient adds to the apparent conductivity; the conductivity here is conductive only, which is exact for isothermal sintering. One clause here or in Section 2.3.
   - [wording] "effects": "affects". "macroscopic bodies of icy porous materials": "bulk properties of porous ice". "here on earth": "on Earth". "Significant work ... are needed": "is needed".

8. **What follows** (L150–164)

   *The order of the paper and its findings.*

   - [correct] "is independent of the mean temperature field and weakly dependent on the initial porosity": the relation is independent of temperature; across porosity the exponent is shared ($-0.80$ for $\varphi \leq 0.375$) while the level is not ($k_{\mathrm{eff,r}}$ falls about threefold from $\varphi = 0.275$ to

0.475). "Weakly" undersells the second part. Also "SSA … is independent": it is the relation between conductivity and SSA that is independent of temperature, not SSA.

- [correct] "use their results to compare with their model": three "their"s. "compare our model with their measurements and with their sintering model".
- [correct] "an updated phase-field model introduced by Moure & Fu": see paragraph 6; "the ice–air form of the phase-field model of Moure & Fu (2024)".
- [add] **The temperature result is not announced.** That temperature from −40 to −5 °C only rescales time (the $\tau_{\mathrm{sub}}$ clock, Section 5.2) is one of the paper's two results. One clause.
- [add] **Scope, in one clause** (decided 10-08): isothermal, air at 1 atm, two dimensions, temperatures a laboratory can reach. This is where a reader learns the paper does not model Enceladus conditions directly.
- [add] "what is new": the thin-interface kinetics and the homogenization in the diffuse interface (tensor law; prior art Nicoli et al., 2011, `nicoli_tensorial_2011`). One clause, so "updated" has content.
- [wording] "over 2D packings … over 30-day time periods": "in two-dimensional packings of ice grains for 30 days". "a diffuse interface adapted homogenization technique initially outlined by": "a homogenization method (Auriault, 1991) adapted to the diffuse interface". "we will present": "we present". "the temperature and water vapor density fields": the model also tracks the phase field.

# 2 Modeling Approach

*Draft heading: 2 Modelling Approach.*

1. **Section opening** (L166–173)

   *Says the model follows Kaempfer & Plapp and Moure & Fu.*

   - [wording] "The scientific novelty in this work is much more an application of the model, rather than advancing the numerical methods": "The contribution here is the application of the model, not the method".
   - [trim] The last three sentences are repeated in the first lines of Section 2.1. Three sentences are enough.
   - [add] One sentence of lineage from the Discussion's second paragraph (L412–424) can move here.

## 2.1 Phase-Field Model of Dry Snow Metamorphism

1. **What a phase field is** (L175–182)

   *General description of the method.*

   - [wording] "representing the volume fraction of phase $l$ at a given point … and evolves through time": the sentence changes subject midway.
   - [trim] Textbook material; one sentence.

2. **Unknowns** (L183–189)

*Lists the four fields.*

- [correct] "water vapor $\phi_a$": $\phi_a$ is the air phase.
- [correct] $T$ is given in °C here and used as $T + T_0$ in Eqs. (3), (5); Table 1 and Eq. (7) need kelvin. Choose one.
- [wording] "derived from the free energy potential and allows": "that allows".
- [trim] The last two sentences ("defined pointwise", "benefit from the phase-field formulation") can go.

3. **Scope** (to write)

   *Says which part of dry snow metamorphism the model contains.*

   - [add] The model carries sintering by vapor transport: sublimation, diffusion through the pore, desublimation.
   - [add] Not in it: surface diffusion, grain-boundary processes, densification, overburden. Define desublimation.
   - [add] Say plainly that vapor-transport sintering does not densify: grain centres do not approach, so porosity is constant in every run. This answers the porosity named in the Introduction's first paragraph.
   - [add] Hence the laboratory analogues are unloaded ice-sphere samples, not natural snow.

4. **Model equations and the phase equation** (L190–196)

   *Eq. (1) and the meaning of its terms.*

   - [correct] Eq. (1b): the latent-heat term should carry $\rho_{\text{ice}}$, as the solver does, not the mixture density, which integrates to about half across the interface.
   - [correct] "$\varepsilon$ represents the interface width": it is the interface parameter; the visible band is $9.2\,\varepsilon$ (Table 3 says so).
   - [correct] Eq. (1c) as printed has no $\xi_v$, but Tables 3 and 4 list $\xi_v = 10^{-3}$. Show it or explain it in one sentence.
   - [wording] "Allen-Kahn" (Cahn); "localize this phenomena" (localizes this term); the sentence defining $\alpha_{\text{sub}}$ and $\rho_i$ is run together.
   - [add] $M_{\text{sub}}$ and $\alpha_{\text{sub}}$ are named and never given: $M_{\text{sub}} = \varepsilon/(3\tau_{\text{sub}})$, $\alpha_{\text{sub}} = \lambda_{\text{sub}}/\tau_{\text{sub}}$, or a pointer to Moure & Fu.

5. **Saturation vapor density** (L197–201)

   *Eqs. (2) and (3).*

   - [correct] Eq. (3): the last term reads $k_5 + \ln(T + T_0)$; the source form is probably $k_5 \ln(T + T_0)$. Check.
   - [correct] The text cites Flatau and Wexler; the note to Table 1 says ASHRAE.
   - [wording] "saturated vapor density of ice" (over ice); "$\rho_a$ and $P_a$ is" (are); Table 1 calls them $\rho_{\text{air}}$, $P_{\text{atm}}$.

6. **Energy equation** (L202–208)

   *Eq. (1b) and the mixture rules.*

   - [correct] "latent heat released and absorbed during sublimation and desublimation, respectively": reversed. Sublimation absorbs heat; desublimation releases it.

- [wording] "phase dependent": hyphenate.

7. **Vapor equation** (L209–215)

   *Eq. (1c) and the diffusivity.*

   - [trim] $T_0$ is defined at L199 and again here.
   - [wording] "The rest of the thermophysical properties are shown in": "Material properties are listed in".

| **Table 1** [written] Material properties, cited at L214. |
|---|

## 2.2 Interface Kinetics and the Sintering Time Scale

*Draft heading: 2.2 Gibbs-Thomson Condition.*

1. **The interface condition** (L216–226)

   *Eqs. (6) and (7).*

   - [wording] "is commonly interchanged with the condensation coefficient": "is commonly expressed through". "molecular mass a water molecule" (mass of a water molecule).
   - [add] $d_0 = \gamma m/(\rho_{\text{ice}} k_B T)$ is defined only in Table 1.

2. **The thin-interface limit** (to write)

   *What "under the conditions outlined by Kaempfer & Plapp" means.*

   - [add] The model recovers Eq. (6) with a kinetic coefficient $\beta_{\text{sub}} + \Delta\beta$, $\Delta\beta = a_1 a_2\, \varepsilon\, (D_T^{-1} + D_v^{-1})\, \rho_{\text{ice}}/\rho_{vs}^I$.
   - [add] Its size: 2% of $\beta_{\text{sub}}$ in the aggregates, 0.2% in the saturated pair, 23% in the Molaro pairs.

   **Cite:** Kaempfer & Plapp 2009 `kaempferPhasefieldModelingDry2009`; Moure & Fu 2024 `mourePhaseFieldModelWet2024`.

3. **The time scale** (to write here; now at L469–477 in the Discussion)

   *Defines $\tau_{\text{sub}}$ and the sintering age $\theta$.*

   - [add] Move Eq. ($\tau_{\text{sub}}$) from Section 5.1 to here, and define $\theta = t/\tau_{\text{sub}}$ here, not in Section 4.2.
   - [add] Two time scales of the same form $\ell^2\beta/d_0$: $\tau_{\text{sub}}$ ($\ell = \varepsilon$), the relaxation time of the diffuse interface; and $\tau_{\bar{R}} = \bar{R}^2\beta/d_0$, the time for a grain to change shape. $\tau_{\text{sub}} = \tau_{\bar{R}}/2500$ in every aggregate run.
   - [add] The 30-day runs end at $\theta = 43$ ($-40\,^\circ$C) to 1256 ($-5\,^\circ$C). Cite Table 2 here.

4. **The values used** (to write)

   *The condensation coefficients and why they are constant.*

   - [add] $\alpha_c = 1.020 \times 10^{-3}$ (aggregates), 0.1 (Molaro pairs), $1.002 \times 10^{-3}$ (saturated pair), constant in temperature.
   - [add] Why constant: a temperature-dependent $\alpha_c$ would make a temperature sweep uninterpretable.

**Cite:** range of $\alpha_c$: Braun et al. 2024 `braunRigorousApproachSpecific2024`; Bouvet et al. 2022 `bouvetSnowEquiTemperatureMetamorphism2022`; Libbrecht 2017 `libbrechtPhysicalDynamicsIce2017`.

**Table 2** [written] Temperature-dependent quantities, placed. [add] Not cited in the text.

## 2.3 Effective Thermal Conductivity by Homogenization

*Draft heading: 2.3 Homogenizing for Effective Thermal Conductivity.*

1. **Two scales and the microscale problem** (L228–238)

   *Scale separation, periodicity, Eq. (8).*

   - [correct] "without less of generality": periodicity is an assumption, not a convenience (and the phrase is "loss").
   - [wording] "A smaller length scale $l$ describing ..., and $L$ describing ..." is not a sentence. "representative element volume" (elementary). "diffusive heat transfer" (conductive). "upscaling effective thermal conductivity" (computing the).

2. **Macroscale law and cell problem** (L239–247)

   *Eqs. (9)–(11).*

   - [correct] Eq. (11d) has $\mathbf{t}$ where it needs $\nabla\mathbf{t}$.
   - [wording] "are commonly referred to as co the solutions": the sentence is broken. "the corresponding macroscopic description is described as".
   - [trim] "Equations ... are then coupled with the boundary conditions ..." says the equations go with their own boundary conditions; cut.

3. **Single-domain form** (L248–260)

   *Weak form and the indicator function, Eqs. (12)–(15).*

   - [correct] The test function is scalar $v$ in the text and bold $\mathbf{v}$ in Eq. (12). $K_\star$ in Eqs. (13)–(14) becomes $K_*$ in Eq. (15).
   - [wording] "as diffuse interface model" (as a); "in 2.1" (Section 2.1); "We can the define" (then); "$\zeta = 1.0$" (1).
   - [trim] Eqs. (12)–(14) can be one sentence: summing the weak forms over the two subdomains, the interface terms cancel by flux continuity, and Eq. (15) follows.

4. **Diffuse form and the tensor law** (L261–275)

   *Eqs. (16), (17) and why the conductivity is a tensor in the interface.*

   - [correct] "interpolates between 0 and 1": between $K_{\text{air}}$ and $K_{\text{ice}}$.
   - [wording] "along the our phase-field"; "$K_\parallel(\phi)$ and are $K_\perp(\phi)$ the"; "We then may write diffuse BVP" (the diffuse); "tonsorial" (tensorial); "interface width $\varepsilon$". $\phi$ and $\phi_i$ are used for the same field; $t_\star$ is not bold.
   - [add] Credit and what is new: Nicoli, Plapp & Henry (2011) define the law and show the cancellation for a planar interface at contrasts of 2 and 10; here it is applied to the cell problem at a contrast of 115 and verified on laminate and disk-array cases (supplement).
   - [add] Why it matters here: with a scalar law the bias reaches tens of percent and grows with $\varepsilon$ SSA, so it would drift as the aggregate sinters.

- [add] The cell problem is solved on frozen snapshots of $\phi$.

**Cite:** Nicoli, Plapp & Henry 2011 `nicoli_tensorial_2011`; Auriault 1991 `auriaultHeterogeneousMediumEquivalent1991`; Calonne et al. 2011 `calonneNumericalExperimentalInvestigations2011`.

5. **What is reported** (to write)

   *Defines the quantities the results plot.*

   - [add] $\mathbf{K}_{\text{eff}}$ in the diffuse form, the one evaluated (Eq. 10 is the sharp form only).
   - [add] The scalar $k_{\text{eff}} = (k_{xx} + k_{yy})/2$, now defined only in the Figure 6 caption.
   - [add] SSA: how it is measured from $\phi$, and its units. It is used throughout Section 4 and defined nowhere.

   **Cite:** for computing SSA from a field, possibly Flin et al. 2014 `flinComputationsSpecificSurface2014` (check that the method matches).

| **Figure 2** [written] placed. [add] Not cited in the text. Caption: see "Figure captions" after Section 6. |
|---|

## 2.4 Numerical Implementation

1. **Discretization and time stepping** (to write; heading only at L276)

   *Enough for someone to reproduce the runs.*

   - [add] Quadratic $C^1$ splines; element size $\varepsilon/\sqrt{2}$.
   - [add] Adaptive step capped at $2\,\tau_{\text{sub}}$ in the aggregates. The grain-pair runs use larger caps ($5\ \tau_{\text{sub}}$ for the saturated pair; 30 s, i.e. 22 $\tau_{\text{sub}}$, for Molaro $-20\,^{\circ}\text{C}$); say so.
   - [add] Conductivity sampled every step for $\theta < 11$, then at every 0.1% drop in SSA.

2. **Checks** (to write)

   *The results do not depend on domain size, time step or sampling.*

   - [add] One sentence each, pointing to the supplement: domain size (Fig. S1); interface parameter (Fig. S2), including that the first day depends on $\varepsilon$ and later rates do not; time step and sampling (Fig. S3).

| **Table 3** [written] Complete parameters, placed. [add] Not cited in the text. *Open: keep it here, or the short version here and this one in the supplement.* |
|---|

## 2.5 Simulation Design: Grain Pairs and Aggregates

1. **Grain pairs** (to write; heading only at L277; material now at L301–313 and L326–331)

   *What the three two-grain simulations are.*

   - [add] Axisymmetric about the line of centers; fixed temperature and humidity on the outer boundary; how the neck width $w$ is measured.
   - [add] The two Molaro geometries and the equal-grain pair ($R = 84.4\ \mu$m, $-20\,^{\circ}$C, 100 h).
   - [add] Every pair starts from two overlapping spheres with a neck 28 $\mu$m wide, not from grains that just touch. Say so here; it matters for the exponents (Section 3.2).

**Table 4** [written] Two-grain parameters. [add] Add a column for the saturated pair. [correct] Simulated time at −5 °C is 68 min, not 2 h.

2. **Aggregates** (to write; material now at L343–352)

   *What the 125 aggregate simulations are and how the packings were made.*

   - [add] 2 mm square, periodic in both directions; circular grains, log-normal radii with mean 50 $\mu$m, placed by drop-and-roll deposition.
   - [add] Five porosities, five independent packings each, the same packings at all five temperatures: 125 runs of 30 days; uniform temperature, vapor initially at saturation.
   - [add] Domain size $L/\bar{R} = 40$, at the 1–2 mm representative volume of Calonne et al. (2011). Packings are accepted only if contacts across the periodic seam are as dense as in the interior.

   **Cite:** representative volume: Calonne et al. 2011 `calonneNumericalExperimentalInvestigations2011`.

3. **Why periodic, why two dimensions** (to write)

   *Justifies the two choices a reviewer will question first.*

   - [add] Periodic: the domain stands for the interior of a deposit, no wall physics has to be invented, and the system is closed, so curvature alone drives transport.
   - [add] Two dimensions: cost (now at L290–291, in the wrong place); what it costs is discussed in Section 5.6.

# 3 Neck Growth Between Two Ice Grains

1. **Section opening** (L279–294)

   *Announces the findings.*

   - [correct] It was written as the opening of a single Results section and still announces the aggregate findings of Section 4.
   - [correct] "independent of the mean temperature as well as the initial porosity"; "our model's ability to capture sintering dynamics for varying temperatures": neither is what the results show.
   - [correct] "theorized trends from Demmenie et al.": they measured the exponent as well. "dominated by vapor transport": the $t^{1/3}$ law is for sublimation and desublimation limited by attachment.
   - [wording] "simulation results, which captures" (capture); "related the evolution" (to the); "microstructures SSA" (microstructure's).
   - [trim] Two sentences: before using the model on aggregates, we ask how much of measured neck growth it reproduces, with one experiment away from saturation and one at saturation.

## 3.1 Comparison With Unsaturated Experiments

1. **Why these experiments** (L295–300)

   *Why Molaro et al. is the comparison.*

- [correct] "relatively well-controlled": the humidity was not reported and the grains sublimated; Section 5.1 argues the conditions were not controlled at the level of the driving force. Say "among the few that isolate a grain pair at these sizes and temperatures".
- [wording] "are good candidate" (a good candidate); "validating" (testing); "that exist that isolates" (isolate).

2. **What is fitted and what is not** (L301–313)

   *The set-up of the −20 °C run.*

   - [correct] "The only free-parameter in our model is … $\beta_{\text{sub}}$": the humidity is fitted too.
   - [correct] "over a 78 minute period": Molaro's text describes their Figure 11 as 57 min apart; our digitized series runs to 78 min. Check which figure the series comes from and cite it.
   - [correct] "within a sealed cryostage": their text says the sample area was not sealed off from the chamber, and the grains shrank.
   - [wording] "fig. 11" (their Figure 11); "We assumed a value … and was at the upper end" (state $\alpha_c = 0.1$); "(cite other works as well)"; "table table 4".
   - [add] The inferred humidity, 0.99715 at −20 °C and 0.99674 at −5 °C, from the shrinkage of the large grain.
   - [trim] Geometry and boundary conditions move to Section 2.5.

3. **Result** (L314–324)

   *Figure 3: model against measurement.*

   - [wording] "Panel (a) we see" (shows); "the a digital replicate"; "corresponds final temporal data point"; "over approximates and under approximates" (overpredicts, underpredicts); "will discussed" (be); "section section 5.1"; "that they cryostage chamber".
   - [add] The numbers: 41% of the measured neck growth at −20 °C over 78 min; 170% at −5 °C over 48 min (52.1 against 44.0 μm).
   - [add] Panels (c), (d): the shrinkage is what the humidity was fitted to, so they are a calibration, not a test.
   - [add] Molaro's conventions are used (neck width; time from the first measurement). Their own model matches through its vapor term, which assumes $\alpha_c = 1$ and no gas diffusion.

   **Cite:** Molaro et al. 2019 `molaroMicrostructuralEvolutionWater2019`.

| **Figure 3** [written] placed. Caption: see "Figure captions" after Section 6. |
|---|

## 3.2 Growth at Saturation

1. **Set-up and result** (L326–340)

   *The saturated equal-grain run and its fitted exponent.*

   - [correct] "a vapor-limited regime … governed by vapor transport": the reverse. At $\alpha_c = 10^{-3}$ growth is limited by attachment (gas diffusion adds 0.4–2% to the resistance), which is the regime the $t^{1/3}$ law describes.
   - [correct] "two ice grains briefly brought into contact": the run starts from a neck 28 μm wide.

- [correct] "The red dashed curve is the theoretical fit": it is the best fit with the exponent fixed at 1/3.
- [wording] "in attempts to compare" (to compare); "allowed for the to sinter"; "an condensation"; "$1.002e-03$" ($1.002 \times 10^{-3}$); "Similarly to".
- [add] Why this run: at saturation the grains do not shrink (radius +0.06%), so neck growth is isolated. Neck from 28 to 63 $\mu$m.
- [add] Demmenie et al. measure 0.26–0.33 at saturation and about 1/7 when undersaturated. The fitted exponent rises from 0.21 to 0.24 as the window starts later. The unsaturated $-20\,^{\circ}$C run gives 0.135 (Molaro's data $0.23 \pm 0.03$). No exponent at $-5\,^{\circ}$C.

**Cite:** Demmenie et al. 2025 `demmenieIceSinteringSublimation2025`.

2. **Why the exponent is low** (to write; provisional until the tangent-start run is in)

   *The sharp-interface law gives 0.29 for this run; the 0.21 comes from the neck it was started from.*

   - [add] The Gibbs–Thomson prediction for this geometry and these parameters: exponent 0.29, final neck width within 4%.
   - [add] The starting neck is two overlapping spheres: a sharp notch, with the centers 2.3 $\mu$m closer than touching grains.
   - [add] The run grows faster than the prediction at first (2.5 times at 2 h) and settles onto it (1.0 by 71 h).
   - [add] The fit must assume how long the neck had been growing: a free fit takes 4.8 h and gives 0.21; the prediction says 16 h, and with that the same data give 0.28.
   - [add] The run from grains just touching: *fill in from the pending run.* (The August run of that kind, at twice the interface width, gave 0.283 with no early excess.)
   - [add] The limit of the claim: within 100 h the rate reaches the prediction but the fitted exponent does not (0.236 against 0.29).

   *Open: if the pending run still shows the early excess at equal neck widths, the cause is the interface width instead. A claim of convergence as $\varepsilon \to 0$ is not available without a run at smaller $\varepsilon$.*

**Figure 4** [written] placed. Caption: see "Figure captions" after Section 6.

# 4 Thermal Conductivity of Sintering Aggregates

## 4.1 Microstructural Evolution

1. **Set-up and the gallery** (L343–361)

   *States the simulation matrix, then describes Figure 5.*

   - [correct] "mesh of size $2829 \times 2928$": 2829 both ways.
   - [correct] "We initially consider a single 2D microstructure": the previous sentence states 125 runs, and Figure 5 shows five.
   - [correct] "periodic boundary conditions for our equation (1b) and (1c)": all three fields are periodic.

- [correct] "By the 10 day snapshot for each porosity … a well connected icy porous matrix": the ice already spans the cell at $t = 0$ in 24 of 25 packings; what changes is that point contacts become necks. At the two highest porosities the network stays anisotropic.
- [wording] "Next, we aim to better understand … to better understand" (twice); "five different configurations for five separate porosities" (five packings at each of five porosities); "drop and roll" (hyphens); "gravitational affects" (effects); "a a".
- [trim] The set-up (first half) moves to Section 2.5.
- [add] What the colors show: vapor is undersaturated over convex ice, which sublimates, and supersaturated in necks and concavities, where it desublimates.

**Figure 5** [written] placed. Caption: see "Figure captions" after Section 6.

### 4.2 Temperature Rescales Time

2. **Computing the conductivity** (L362–371)

   *Applies the homogenization and describes the tensor.*

   - [correct] "We obtain … $\mathbf{K}_{\text{eff}}$ by integrating (17a) and applying the zero mean condition": it is the volume average of $\mathbf{K}(\nabla \mathbf{t} + \mathbf{I})$ over the cell (Eq. 10 in diffuse form).
   - [correct] "off diagonal components are at least one order of magnitude lower": $k_{xy}$ reaches about 12% of $k_{xx}$ on one packing; it is zero in the mean.
   - [wording] "changes … is expected" (are); "figure figure 6"; "correspond the the"; "lower that" (than); "over various seeds" (packings).
   - [trim] The two sentences on solving Eq. (17) on the same mesh repeat Section 2.3.
   - [add] Anisotropy: $k_{xx}/k_{yy} = 1.02,\ 1.03,\ 0.93,\ 0.82,\ 0.66$ from the lowest porosity to the highest, with $y$ the direction of deposition. The scalar $k_{\text{eff}}$ is used from here on.

3. **Figure 6, one packing at five temperatures** (L372–381)

   *Conductivity and SSA against time and against sintering age.*

   - [correct] "After the first day": that is 11 $\tau_{\text{sub}}$ at $-20\,^{\circ}\text{C}$ only; the relaxation period is a fixed number of $\tau_{\text{sub}}$, so it is 0.26 d at $-5\,^{\circ}\text{C}$ and 7.7 d at $-40\,^{\circ}\text{C}$.
   - [correct] "the trend is linear": linear in $\log\theta$, about 0.13 per decade.
   - [wording] "local sintering occurs at high rates … and the phase-field interface relaxes" joins two different things; "non-dimensional" here, "nondimensional" in the caption.
   - [add] Panel (a) is not mentioned.
   - [add] The result as a number: against $\theta$ the rates follow $\tau_{\text{sub}}$ within 4%; against SSA the five temperatures agree within 0.27% for every one of the 25 packings (median 0.07%).
   - [add] A size that does not depend on $\varepsilon$: between $\theta = 30$ and 331, $k_{\text{eff}}$ rises by a factor $1.171 \pm 0.015$ and SSA falls to $0.819 \pm 0.007$, for $\varphi \leq 0.375$.
   - [add] Why curves are normalized at $\theta_r = 30$ and not at $t = 0$: the first day depends on the interface parameter (Fig. S2).

   **Cite:** for SSA against log time in isothermal snow: Legagneux & Dominé 2005 `legagneuxMeanFieldModel2005`; Taillandier et al. 2007 `taillandierRateDecreaseSpecific2007` (functional form only; verify).

**Figure 6** [written] placed. Caption: see "Figure captions" after Section 6.

### 4.3 Conductivity as a Function of Specific Surface Area

4. **Figure 7, porosity** (L382–400)

   *One paragraph covering all four panels.*

   - [correct] "15 unique packings–3 packings for each porosity": five packings at each of three porosities.
   - [correct] "We show the time evolution of $k_{\text{eff}}$ for each of the simulations": panel (a) is $-20\,°\text{C}$ only, the mean of five packings and their range.
   - [correct] "the ice matrix remains disconnected in the horizontal direction": not so. The ice spans the cell in both directions in every packing from 10 d on (percolation test). What happens is that the packings become anisotropic and the two directions follow different laws: along the deposition direction the exponent stays at $-0.79$ to $-0.86$ up to $\varphi = 0.425$; across it, $-0.70$, $-0.60$, $-0.48$ from $\varphi = 0.375$ on.
   - [correct] "The linear trend" in panel (c): the axis is logarithmic; the fit is exponential in porosity.
   - [wording] "may effect" (affect); "scientifically their connectivity as." is unfinished; "the strength of the reference value" (the reference value); "each of the the"; "A single point ... show" (shows); "panels(c)".
   - [trim] One paragraph carries four panels; split into three: (a); (b); (c) and (d).
   - [add] Why four temperatures: the $-40\,°\text{C}$ runs end at $\theta = 43$, too soon after the reference age.
   - [add] The numbers. Exponent $-0.80$; by porosity $-0.79$, $-0.82$, $-0.78$, then $-0.73$, $-0.63$. Level $k_{\text{eff},r}/k_{\text{ice}} = 1.37\exp(-5.01\,\varphi)$ for $\varphi \leq 0.375$, 6.6% scatter between packings. At 30 d the conductivity differs by a factor of about 3.3 across porosity.
   - [add] What it amounts to: SSA gives the relative change in conductivity; porosity gives the level; neither alone gives both.

   *Open: whether to plot or tabulate the directional exponents; whether to add that a porosity-dependent representative volume may contribute (not tested: the domain-size study was run at $\varphi = 0.325$ only).*

   | **Figure 7** [written] placed. Caption: see "Figure captions" after Section 6. |
   |---|

5. **What the scatter is** (optional; to write)

   *Differences between packings in the exponent are properties of the packings, not noise.*

   - [add] The scatter in the exponent does not fall with domain size while the scatter in the level does (11% to 4.5%).

   *Open: include here, in Section 5.3, or leave out.*

## 5 Discussion

Paragraphs 1–3 of Section 5.1 and the start of Section 5.2 are drafted.

(a) **Section opening** (L402–411)

*Recaps the paper.*

- [correct] "our model is able to capture the trends in sintering dynamics at multiple temperatures": at $-20\,^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$ it gives 41% and at $-5\,^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$ 170%.
- [trim] The third statement of the plan (after the Introduction and the opening of Section 3). Not needed.

(b) **Lineage of the model** (L412–424)

*Kaempfer & Plapp, Moure & Fu, and what this paper adds.*

- [wording] "They also, qualitatively validate"; "has since become popular method".
- [trim] Belongs in the Methods opening, in one or two sentences.

## 5.1 What Vapor Transport Alone Reproduces

1. **The unsaturated pair** (L426–452)

*Why the model gives 41% of Molaro's neck growth and what that does and does not mean.*

- [correct] "underpredicts ... overpredicts ... by 41% and 170%": the model gives 41% *of* the measured growth at $-20\,^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$ (it underpredicts by 59%) and 170% of it at $-5\,^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$.
- [correct] "It does not account for surface diffusion, which is expected [to] contribute significantly" (twice): by Molaro's own equations surface diffusion is below 1% of vapor transport at these neck sizes (Appendix A). Remove.
- [correct] "This result was expected": it was not.
- [correct] "The chamber being unsaturated ... [is] likely the reason why our model predictions overestimate": the undersaturation is already in the model, through the inferred humidity.
- [wording] "preformed" (performed); "the the"; "our model own accounts" (only accounts); "expected contribute"; the three sentences from "Furthermore, our model also underestimates" appear twice.
- [trim] The first three sentences repeat Section 3.1.
- [add] "Even with the vapor diffusivity raised 30 or 100 times": say these were tests not shown, and that the neck was insensitive to the chamber humidity at the nominal diffusivity.
- [add] How small the driving force is: $4.8 \times 10^{-4}$ falling to $9 \times 10^{-5}$ in relative vapor density, the equivalent of 4.9 to 1.0 mK; the chamber's undersaturation is $2.85 \times 10^{-3}$, 6 to 31 times larger.
- [add] What that makes the result sensitive to, without choosing: (i) how much of the ambient undersaturation reaches the neck (about 6% in our run; with none, the one-equation neck model gives 66% of the growth and an exponent of 0.23, Molaro's value); (ii) temperature differences of millikelvin between neck and grain surface; (iii) $\alpha_c$ above 0.1 for droplets quenched in liquid nitrogen.
- [add] Latent heat is not a candidate: in the run the neck is 0.002 mK warmer than the grain surface.
- [add] Molaro's own model matches through a vapor term with $\alpha_c = 1$ and no gas diffusion, and they present its agreement as order-of-magnitude.
- [add] Why the saturated experiment is the better test: it removes the undersaturation.

**Cite:** Molaro et al. 2019 `molaroMicrostructuralEvolutionWater2019`; Swinkels & Ashby 1981 `swinkelsSecondReportSintering1981`.

2. **The saturated pair, and exponents** (L453–468; provisional until the tangent-start run is in)

   *The model follows the saturation trend in the exponent; where it falls short, the cause is the starting neck.*

   - [correct] "As two spherical ice grains sinter in an environment with a saturated water vapor field, the growth is expected to be kinetics limited": saturation does not make growth attachment-limited; a small $\alpha_c$ does. The $t^{1/3}$ law assumes it.
   - [correct] "a much better match for the theorized scaling … $t^{1/7}$": say who reports 1/7 for undersaturated conditions (Demmenie et al.) and that it is an observation there.
   - [correct] "they are lower than measured values": give the pairs, 0.21 against 0.26–0.33 at saturation and 0.135 against $0.23 \pm 0.03$ at $-20\,^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$.
   - [wording] The first sentence is unfinished ("growing under as ."); "where observe"; "we had considered"; "$1.002e-03$"; "preform" (perform); two sentences in a row begin "We additionally" and "Additionally".
   - [add] "We additionally compare our measured interface velocity …" states no result: 2.5 times the Gibbs–Thomson value at 2 h, 1.0 by 71 h; the prediction's exponent is 0.29.
   - [add] The reason for the shortfall, from Section 3.2, in two sentences. The Molaro runs start from the same pre-made neck and their comparison begins about 100 $\tau_{\mathrm{sub}}$ after the start.
   - [add] Why not surface diffusion: mechanisms in parallel add their rates, and surface diffusion alone gives $t^{1/7}$, so adding it could not raise an exponent toward 1/3.

   **Cite:** Demmenie et al. 2025 `demmenieIceSinteringSublimation2025`; Molaro et al. 2019 `molaroMicrostructuralEvolutionWater2019`.

3. $\alpha_c$ **as an effective parameter** (L469–477)

   *What the uncertain coefficient does and does not change.*

   - [correct] "do not change how the microstructure evolves, just the rate": true only while growth is limited by attachment. $\alpha_c$ sets the time scale ($\tau_{\mathrm{sub}} \propto 1/\alpha_c$) *and* the group $\Lambda = L^*/\bar{R} \propto 1/\alpha_c$ that decides how much gas diffusion matters. In the aggregates $\Lambda \approx 2.8$. A smaller $\alpha_c$ only rescales time; a larger one brings diffusion in and changes the path as well. (An earlier version of this outline said a tenfold larger $\alpha_c$ would leave the curves unchanged against $\theta$; that was wrong.)
   - [correct] "$\Delta\beta/\beta_{\mathrm{sub}} = 0.02$" for both the aggregates and the saturated pair: it is 0.02, 0.002, and 0.23 for the Molaro pairs.
   - [correct] The sentence on Bouvet et al. rescaling time through $\alpha_c$ cites the 2023 paper; check that it is the one (the fit of $\alpha_c$ to tomography is Bouvet et al., 2022).
   - [wording] "The kinetic attachment parameter, and thus condensation coefficient, do not"; "$\mu$m-CT" ($\mu$CT).
   - [trim] Eq. ($\tau_{\mathrm{sub}}$) and the sentence after it move to Section 2.2.
   - [add] What $\alpha_c$ does to the two grain-pair comparisons: Molaro's rate wants a large value (41% at 0.1; 51–75% at 0.8 in the one-equation neck model), while the sharp-interface exponent at saturation falls with it (0.29 at $10^{-3}$, 0.25 at $10^{-2}$, 0.18 at 0.1). One value cannot serve both.
   - [add] [from the notes] Bouvet et al. fit $\alpha_c = (9.8 \pm 0.7) \times 10^{-4}$ to tomography at $-2\,^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$; Braun et al. find $10^{-3}$–$10^{-1}$, changing as surfaces facet, and call it an effective, surface-averaged value.

**Cite:** Bouvet et al. 2022 `bouvetSnowEquiTemperatureMetamorphism2022`; Braun et al. 2024 `braunRigorousApproachSpecific2024`; Granger et al. 2021 `grangerOrientationSelectiveGrain2021` for faceting under a gradient; Libbrecht & Rickerby 2013 `libbrechtMeasurementsSurfaceAttachment2013` as background on why $\alpha_c$ is uncertain.

## 5.2 Temperature as a Rescaling of Time

4. **Why the curves superpose** (L479–487; breaks off at "Since we have already")

   *A similarity argument: in dimensionless form, almost all of the temperature dependence is in one time scale.*

   - **[correct]** "$\beta_{\text{sub}}$, which is a free variable": it is set by $\alpha_c$, which is chosen, and it depends on temperature through $\rho_{vs}^{I}(T)$. That dependence is the point of the paragraph.
   - **[wording]** "is evident … and is evident"; "a two part series" (two steps in series); "drawn to areas of lower vapor saturation".
   - **[add]** Step 1. Scale lengths by $\bar{R}$, supersaturation by $d_0/\bar{R}$, time by $\tau_{\bar{R}} = \bar{R}^2\beta/d_0$ ($= 2500\,\tau_{\text{sub}}$). The interface condition becomes parameter-free. The saturation vapor density, with its 31-fold change from $-40$ to $-5\,^{\circ}\text{C}$, is entirely inside the time scale.
   - **[add]** Step 2. One temperature-dependent group is left, $\Lambda = L^*/\bar{R}$ with $L^* = (D_v/\alpha_c)\sqrt{2\pi m/k_B T}$. The saturation vapor density cancels in it; what remains is the diffusivity. It changes by 20% where the time scale changes by a factor of 29.
   - **[add]** Step 3. So the saturation vapor density sets the clock, and the diffusivity is a weak remaining correction: the likely source of the 4% by which rates depart from $\tau_{\text{sub}}$ (consistent in size; not tested as the cause).
   - **[add]** Say plainly that with one sintering mechanism this is close to a consequence of the construction; the numerical result is how well it holds. Do not say gas diffusion is negligible ($\Lambda \approx 2.8$); what is small is its change with temperature.
   - **[add]** The two-page derivation (`temperature_scaling/time_temperature_scaling.pdf`) can be an appendix or supporting information.

5. **What would break it, and the activation energy.** (new) **[to write]**

   **Message:** *The collapse is therefore a signature of a single route. Its temperature dependence differs from the one measured for strength gain, which points to a second route in real samples and gives experimenters something to measure.*

   The clock's temperature dependence is an activation energy of about 50 $\text{kJ mol}^{-1}$, that of the saturation vapor density. **[from the notes]** Choukroun et al. measure $24.3 \pm 3.3$ $\text{kJ mol}^{-1}$ for strength gain and attribute it to surface self-diffusion (L613–620), at 193–243 K; the two temperature ranges overlap at 233–243 K. The difference is consistent with a second route in their samples, and an activation energy is something a laboratory can measure to tell the routes apart. A temperature-dependent $\alpha_c$, a second route, or a temperature gradient would each break the superposition, which makes it a test.

   **Cite:** Choukroun et al. 2020 `choukroun_strength_2020`.

## 5.3 Specific Surface Area as the State Variable

6. **Density is not enough.** (new) **[to write]**

**Message:** *Conductivity changes while porosity stays fixed, so a density-based formula cannot describe a sintering deposit.*

In these runs porosity is fixed and conductivity still rises, by 17% between $\theta = 30$ and 331. **[from the notes]** Calonne et al. (2011): tensor from 30 tomographic images, a regression on density, scatter attributed to anisotropy (L507–517). Calonne et al. (2014): under a temperature gradient conductivity changes at constant density, with SSA and anisotropy (L517–529). Half the length of the notes.

**Cite:** Calonne et al. 2011 `calonneNumericalExperimentalInvestigations2011`; Calonne et al. 2014 `calonneStudyTemperatureGradient2014`; Schneebeli & Sokratov 2004 `schneebeliTomographyTemperatureGradient2004` (the notes cite it for the same behavior under a gradient).

7. **The power law and where it stops.** (new) **[to write]**

   **Message:** *State the law, its range, and that outside the range we make no claim.*

   $p = -0.80$ for $\varphi \leq 0.375$; the level from porosity; above 0.375 the exponent weakens and the packings are anisotropic. No claim that packings of different porosity converge.

   **Cite:** Calonne et al. 2011, 2019 `calonneNumericalExperimentalInvestigations2011`, `calonneThermalConductivitySnow2019` for conductivity against density, as the contrast.

8. **Why packings differ.** (new) **[to write]**

   **Message:** *Packings of the same porosity conduct differently because their ice networks are arranged differently; at high porosity the networks are anisotropic and the simple law fails in one direction.*

   Packings of one porosity differ in how well the ice is connected, and the exponent follows that (correlation $-0.77$ with conduction efficiency), not coordination number or anisotropy. In these packings the ice always spans the cell and the pore never does (percolation test, 2026-10-12): the pore space is a set of closed pockets, which is what "sealed pores" means here, and in two dimensions only one phase can span. What differs between packings is the quality of the ice network, not whether it exists: at high porosity the packings are anisotropic, grains dropped under gravity being supported from below with fewer contacts sideways, and the power law survives along the deposition direction while failing across it. Absolute values are therefore not compared with three-dimensional measurements, where both phases are connected. *Open: literature thresholds for discs are not yet checked against a source; whether to show the efficiency; the Euler-characteristic series (tested on three runs) is available if a direct measure is wanted.*

## 5.4 What a Laboratory Could Measure

9. **Three tests.** (new) **[to write]**

   **Message:** *Turn the results into measurements someone could make on sintered ice-sphere samples.*

   On unloaded ice-sphere samples held isothermally: (i) curves at different temperatures superpose under a time shift, and the shift gives an activation energy; (ii) conductivity against SSA is one curve; (iii) SSA falls linearly in log time. **[from the notes]** SSA is measured by near-infrared reflectance, gas adsorption and tomography (L562–568; Gallet, Matzl, Proksch).

   **Cite:** Gallet et al. 2009 `galletMeasurementSpecificSurface2009`; Matzl & Schneebeli 2006 `matzlMeasuringSpecificSurface2006`; Proksch et al. 2015 `prokschDensitySpecificSurface2015`; for isothermal SSA decay in the laboratory, Legagneux & Dominé 2005, Taillandier et al. 2007, Kaempfer & Schneebeli 2007 `kaempferObservationIsothermalMetamorphism2007`, Löwe et al. 2011 `loweInterfacialStructuralRelaxations2011` (forms only).

## 5.5 Implications for Plume Deposits on Enceladus

10. **What carries over.** (new) **[to write]**

    **Message:** *For Enceladus the qualitative conclusion holds: a sintering deposit conducts better as its surface area falls, even with no compaction.*

    Qualitative: as a deposit sinters, SSA falls and conductivity rises together, without densification. **[from the notes]** Tiger Stripe temperatures up to about 180 K (Spencer); grain size increasing toward the fractures in VIMS data (Jaumann; L580–602); Molaro et al. on the dependence of sintering on temperature and grain size.

    **Cite:** Spencer et al. 2009 `spencerEnceladusActiveCryovolcanic2009`; Spencer & Nimmo 2013 `spencerEnceladusActiveIce2013`; Jaumann et al. 2008 `jaumannDistributionIcyParticles2008`; Molaro et al. 2019; Choukroun et al. 2020.

11. **Why it matters, and the gap.** (new) **[to write]**

    **Message:** *Conductivity of the surface layer affects thermal and radar interpretation, but our conditions are far from the moon's, so we give no timescales.*

    **[from the notes]** A low-conductivity surface layer changes subsurface temperatures and radar attenuation (Byrne; L603–612); Choukroun et al. on strength gain and fallout rates of 0.01–1 $\mathrm{mm\,yr^{-1}}$ (L613–629). Then the gap, stated plainly: the runs stop at $-40\,^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$ and use 50 $\mu$m grains in air; the moon is far colder, the grains are micron-sized, and there is no air. No timescales are given.

    **Cite:** Byrne et al. 2024 `byrneRadarAttenuationSubsurface2024` (a preprint DOI in the `.bib`; check whether it is published); Choukroun et al. 2020; possibly Ferrari et al. 2021 `ferrariThermalEmissionSaturns2021` on thermal emission of Saturn's icy moons (in your `.bib`; check relevance).

## 5.6 Limitations

12. **Model.** (new) **[to write]**

    **Message:** *What physics is missing.*

    Vapor route only; constant $\alpha_c$; air-filled, sealed pores at 1 atm; conduction only and constant $k_{\mathrm{ice}}$, $k_{\mathrm{air}}$. **[from the notes]** Fourteau et al. on the contribution of vapor transport to apparent conductivity under a gradient (L569–575; check the figure quoted); Calonne et al. (2019) on temperature-dependent conductivities (L575–579).

    **Cite:** Fourteau et al. 2021 — your `.bib` has two, `fourteauImpactWaterVapor2021` and `fourteauMacroscopicWaterVapor2021`; the point about apparent conductivity is the first. Calonne et al. 2019 `calonneThermalConductivitySnow2019`.

13. **Numerics and geometry.** (new) **[to write]**

    **Message:** *What the simulations cannot resolve or represent.*

    Two dimensions, so relative changes are claimed and absolute conductivities are not; one grain size distribution; the first day depends on the interface parameter, and the grain-pair runs start from a neck put in by hand, which grows faster than the Gibbs–Thomson law for the first two thousand $\tau_{\mathrm{sub}}$ or so (Section 3.2), so exponents fitted there are biased low; the Molaro runs use time steps of 22 and 49 $\tau_{\mathrm{sub}}$, outside the range the time-step study covered; pore throats narrower than the diffuse band (9.2 $\mu$m) are not resolved, which raises $k_{\mathrm{eff}}$ most at low porosity; the power law is established for $\varphi \leq 0.375$; rates scale with $1/\alpha_c$, whose value is uncertain over two decades.

**Cite:** none needed beyond those above.

**In the notes and not to be carried over:** $\beta_{\mathrm{sub}}(T)$ from Libbrecht's $\sigma_0(T)$, a single tuning and a "genuine prediction" at $-5\,^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$ (L454–481); isotropy, and a collapse across porosity (L530–561); sintering "on the order of decades" (L596) and conductivity starting "near 0.0" (L611).

## 6 Conclusions

1. **What was done and found.** (new) **[to write]**

   **Message:** *Three results, each with the range over which it was shown.*

   One sentence of method, then the three results with their ranges: temperature rescales time ($-40$ to $-5\,^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$, within 0.3%); conductivity follows $\mathrm{SSA}^{-0.80}$ with the level set by porosity ($\varphi \leq 0.375$); vapor transport gives 41% of measured neck growth at $-20\,^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$.

2. **What comes next.** (new) **[to write]**

   **Message:** *The experiment and the model extensions that would test or extend them.*

   The laboratory test of Section 5.4; a second transport route in the model; three dimensions; colder temperatures and smaller grains.

## Figure captions

Checked against the figure files in the 10-14 upload (rendered here), not only against the text. AGU asks that a caption let the figure be read on its own: what is shown, the conditions, what each line, symbol and color means. Four points apply to several figures:

- **[correct] The $\sigma$ color scale** (Figures 3–6) is relative to a flat ice surface and is clipped. Say both, and give the range. Without this a reader cannot tell why the pore is dark red at saturation (Figure 4) or uniformly dark blue in Molaro's chamber (Figure 3). The scale is symmetric-logarithmic (ticks at $\pm 0.01$ and $\pm$ the maximum): say so.
- **[wording] "vapor saturation filed is colored according the the blue/red colorbar"** (Figures 3, 4): "the supersaturation $\sigma$ is shown on the blue–red scale". "pale-blue" and "pale blue" both occur: one form.
- **[wording] The phase-field colorbar is labeled $\phi_i$** in the art of Figures 3, 4, 6 and in the Figure 2 caption; the text writes $\phi$. One symbol (decided 09-28: $\phi$).
- **[add] Which run.** Every image caption should name the porosity, temperature and domain of what is shown; most do not.

1. **Figure 1, mechanisms and an aggregate** (L268)

   *(a) a grain pair before and after necking; (b) an aggregate at four times.*

   - **[correct] The art says $R(t)$, the caption $w(t)$.** The arrow runs from the axis to the neck surface, i.e. a neck *radius*, while $w$ is the neck *width* everywhere else (Figures 3, 4; Molaro's convention). Relabel the arrow $w(t)$ and draw it across the whole neck, or label it $w/2$.
   - **[correct]** "The neck grows because of both surface diffusion and vapor transport": agree it with paragraph 4 of the Introduction, which now says vapor dominates. "Two routes by which mass reaches the neck; the model contains the second."

- [add] (b): which run (porosity, temperature, seed) and that the panels are at 0, 10, 19 and 30 days; the scale bar is 100 $\mu$m (it is a crop, so say "a region of").
- [wording] "A 2-D cross-section of two spherical ice grains that have undergone sintering. The initially non-sintered touching ice grains (shown as blue dotted line)": "Two ice grains in cross-section, before (dotted) and after (solid) a neck of width $w(t)$ has grown". The grey crosshair lines in (a) are unexplained: remove, or say they are the axes of symmetry.

2. **Figure 2, the homogenization** (L(after 2.3))

   *(a) a cell, (b) the interface and mesh, (c) the corrector, (d) the heat flux.*

   - [add] Not cited in the text (Section 2.3 is the place).
   - [add] Which sample: porosity, temperature, age, and that the cell is 2 mm wide (the scale bar is 500 $\mu$m).
   - [correct] (b): the dashed lines are orange, not red, and are the $\phi = 0.05$ and 0.95 contours; the solid line is $\phi = 0.5$. Write $\phi$, not $\phi_i$.
   - [add] (c): the black contours are the ice–air interface; only the $x$ cell problem is shown ($\mathbf{t}$ has a second component from the $y$ problem). Missing period after (c).
   - [add] (d): color is on a logarithmic scale; "per unit mean gradient in the $x$ direction" is right; "brightness of the path": "brighter paths carry more heat".
   - [wording] "the mesh in which we solve our homogenization model over": "the mesh on which the cell problem is solved".

3. **Figure 3, Molaro et al.** (L(Section 3.1))

   *(a) the pair at the start and at 78 min, (b) neck width, (c), (d) grain diameters.*

   - [correct] **The color scale does not show the chamber.** The far field is undersaturated by $\sigma \approx -2.9 \times 10^{-3}$ (99.715% relative to flat ice), a hundred times beyond the $\pm 0.28 \times 10^{-4}$ scale, so the whole pore sits at the bottom color. Say the scale is clipped to resolve the neck, and give the far-field value.
   - [correct] "On the left is the initial configuration": it is the first measured frame ($t = 0$ is Molaro's first measurement, and the simulation starts from the measured neck). Say so; it is why the curves in (b) start on the first data point. "78 minutes": check against Molaro's text, which describes their Figure 11 as 57 minutes apart (Section 3.1 entry).
   - [add] (b): both temperatures are shown ($-20\,^\circ$C blue, $-5\,^\circ$C vermilion); lines are the model, circles the data, error bars are Molaro's stated uncertainty (check what they are); the numbered circles mark the frames in (a). Give the grain diameters.
   - [correct] (c), (d): "the experimentally measured grain size through time relative to the large and small grains": they show the diameter of the large (c) and small (d) grain divided by its value at $t = 0$; solid lines are the model, circles the data, dashed lines linear fits to the data.
   - [trim] "The simulation is designed to replicate the conditions and geometry ...": belongs in Section 3.1; the caption only needs the conditions.

4. **Figure 4, the saturated pair** (L(Section 3.2))

   *(a) the pair at 0 and 100 h, (b) neck width with two power laws.*

   - [add] **Why the pore is red.** $\sigma$ is relative to flat ice, and Section 3.2 sets the far field to the Gibbs–Thomson value of the grains, $2d_0/R \approx 2.4 \times 10^{-5}$ for $R = 84$ $\mu$m, which is the top of the scale. Say this; a reader expects a saturated pore to be white.

- [add] **The starting neck.** The $t = 0$ frame shows overlapping grains with a neck of 28 $\mu$m. Say so; Section 3.2 and Appendix B rest on it (provisional until the tangent-start run).
- [correct] **The $t^{1/3}$ curve** is called "the power law corresponding to the theorized sublimation/desublimation neck growth": cite Demmenie et al. (2025), as Section 3.2 does (and a classical source, Introduction paragraph 4). Appendix B finds 0.29 for the sharp-interface law at this grain size and $\alpha_c$; if the text compares with 0.29, the figure should show that curve, or both. Decide once the tangent-start run is in.
- [add] The legend writes $C(t + t_0)^a$; say what $t_0$ is (fitted) and the fit window (20 min to 100 h, as Section 3.2 says); temperature $-20\,^\circ$C, $R = 84$ $\mu$m, $\alpha_c = 10^{-3}$; the numbered circles mark the frames in (a).
- [wording] "An isolated ice grain pair shown undergoing sintering shown": "Two equal ice grains sintering in saturated air, at $t = 0$ (left) and 100 h (right)". "filed", "the the".

5. **Figure 5, the gallery** (L(Section 4.1))

   *One packing at each of five porosities, at four times, at $-20\,^\circ$C.*

   - [wording] "Five microstructures of varying porosity $\varphi$ coarsening due to DSM": "One packing at each of five porosities, sintering at $-20\,^\circ$C". Say which seed, and that each cell is 2 mm wide.
   - [add] The vapor colorbar has words but no numbers: give the range, and that $\sigma$ is relative to flat ice and clipped, as in Figure 6.
   - [add] The times (0, 10, 19, 30 d) are the dashed lines in Figure 7(a); one clause linking them.

6. **Figure 6, one packing at five temperatures** (L(Section 4.2))

   *(a) four frames, (b) conductivity against time, (c) against sintering age, (d) SSA against sintering age.*

   - [correct] (a): "$|\sigma| \leq 0.31$": the colorbar says $0.34 \times 10^{-4}$. The factor $10^{-4}$ is missing from the caption.
   - [add] Which packing (it appears to be the $\varphi = 0.325$ packing of Figure 5; say so) and that the frames are at $-20\,^\circ$C, at 0, 10.2, 19.5 and 30.0 days.
   - [add] Define $\theta = t/\tau_{\text{sub}}$ and $\theta_r = 30$ (the dotted line). Say why the curves in (b) start at different values: each is normalized at $\theta_r$, which falls at a different time at each temperature.
   - [add] (c), (d): the five curves overlie (within 0.3%); that is the result, and the caption can say it. Axes start at $\theta = 1$ (log scale).
   - [wording] "preformed" (performed); "2.0mm" (2.0 mm); "The vertical axis is $k_{\text{eff}}$, average value of $k_{xx}$ and $k_{yy}$, is normalized": "$k_{\text{eff}} = (k_{xx} + k_{yy})/2$, normalized ...". "Shows the same curves plotted for": "(c) The same curves against".

7. **Figure 7, porosity** (L(Section 4.3))

   *(a) conductivity against time, (b) against SSA, (c) its reference level, (d) its exponent.*

   - [correct] (a): "The solid line corresponds to a single seed and the highlighted areas are the seed scatter": the line is the mean of five packings and the band their minimum–maximum (as `compare_keff.py` draws it). These are 2-D conductivities in $\mathrm{W\,m^{-1}\,K^{-1}}$; say they are not those of 3-D snow (decided 09-23: no absolute value is claimed).

- [correct] (b): only $\varphi \le 0.375$ is shown (three colors); the caption speaks of "the porosities in panel (a)". Say the higher porosities are left out and why (Section 4.3). $-40\,^\circ$C is absent because those runs end at $\theta = 43$; say so. The grey arrow is the direction of time.
- [correct] (c), (d): one point per packing, temperatures pooled (they coincide at $\theta_r$), not "each of the simulation runs". The dashed line in (c) is a fit to $\varphi \le 0.375$, extended; give its form. The grey band marks the porosities left out of the fits.
- [wording] "Plots the the"; "Shows" at the start of (c), (d); "15 unique packings were used to model DSM at temperatures": "15 packings at each of $-30$, $-20$, $-10$ and $-5\,^\circ$C (60 curves)".

## Open Research; Acknowledgments

[to write] Code and data availability; run inventory (`RUN_TABLE.md`). Acknowledgments.

## Supporting Information

- **Figures.** S1 domain-size convergence; S2 interface parameter; S3 time step and sampling; S4 temperature collapse for all packings; S5 porosity trends, SSA by porosity, anisotropy in time.
- **Tables, text.** Complete parameters, if moved; packing construction; the weak-form derivation, if trimmed; run table.

## Appendix: the two calculations behind Sections 3 and 5.1

### A. Surface diffusion against vapor transport, by Molaro's own equations

**Question.** Does surface diffusion supply the 59% of neck growth our model lacks at $-20\,^\circ$C?

**Equations** (Molaro et al., 2019, Table 3 and Eqs. 1–4, 6, 17–20; $a$ grain radius, $x$ neck radius, $S$ their smoothing factor):

$$\dot{V}_1 = S\,\frac{3\pi x\,\delta_s D_s\,\gamma_s\Omega\,(K_3 - K_2)}{d_2\,kT} \qquad \text{surface diffusion}$$

$$\dot{V}_3 = S\,2\pi x\rho\theta\,P_v\,\frac{\gamma_s\Omega}{kT}\left[\frac{\Omega}{2\pi\Delta_o kT}\right]^{1/2}(K_3 - K_m) \qquad \text{vapor transport}$$

$$\dot{x} = \frac{1}{2\pi x\theta\rho}\sum_i \dot{V}_i$$

$$K_3 = \frac{2}{a},\quad K_m = -\frac{1}{\rho} + \frac{1}{x},\quad \rho = \frac{x^2}{2(a-x)},\quad \theta = \tan^{-1}\frac{a}{x+\rho},\quad K_1K_2 = K_m^2,$$

$$\frac{K_2 - K_1}{K_1} = \frac{3A\rho}{x} + \frac{3}{2} - \frac{3}{2}\left[3\Big(\frac{A\rho}{x}\Big)^2 + \frac{4A\rho}{x} + 1\right]^{1/2},\quad d_2 = \frac{\rho}{1 + \left(\frac{4(K_2-K_1)}{3K_2}\right)^{1/2}},\quad A = \frac{\delta_b D_b}{\delta_s D_s}.$$

The vapor term is Hertz–Knudsen with $\alpha = 1$ and no gas diffusion (their Appendix A).

**Parameters** (their Table 5): $\Omega = 1.181 \times 10^{-29}$ m$^3$; $\Delta_o = 917$ kg m$^{-3}$; $\gamma_s = 0.06$ J m$^{-2}$; $\delta_s = \delta_b = 9.04 \times 10^{-10}$ m; $D_{0s} = 1.4 \times 10^{-8}$ m$^2$ s$^{-1}$ (literature range down to $1.35 \times 10^{-13}$), $Q_s = 23.2$ kJ mol$^{-1}$; $D_{0b} = 8.4 \times 10^{-4}$ m$^2$ s$^{-1}$, $Q_b = 4.9$ kJ mol$^{-1}$; $P_v$ from Murphy & Koop (2005), 103 Pa at $-20$ °C.

**At their experiment** ($a = 87$ $\mu$m, $-20$ °C; measured mean $\dot{x} = 3.4 \times 10^{-9}$ m s$^{-1}$):

| $x$ [$\mu$m] | $\rho$ [$\mu$m] | $\dot{V}_1/\dot{V}_3$ | $\dot{x}$ from $\dot{V}_1$ [m/s] | $\dot{x}$ from $\dot{V}_3$ [m/s] | $\dot{V}_1/\dot{V}_3$, $A = 0$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 16.4 | 1.9 | $6.7 \times 10^{-3}$ | $5 \times 10^{-11}$ | $7.8 \times 10^{-9}$ | $8 \times 10^{-7}$ |
| 20.0 | 3.0 | $3.1 \times 10^{-3}$ | $2 \times 10^{-11}$ | $4.9 \times 10^{-9}$ | $3 \times 10^{-7}$ |
| 25.0 | 5.0 | $1.3 \times 10^{-3}$ | $4 \times 10^{-12}$ | $2.9 \times 10^{-9}$ | $1 \times 10^{-7}$ |
| 32.4 | 9.6 | $4.1 \times 10^{-4}$ | $6 \times 10^{-13}$ | $1.5 \times 10^{-9}$ | $4 \times 10^{-8}$ |

- Surface diffusion is 0.7% falling to 0.04% of their vapor term. It exceeds it only for $x$ below about 4 $\mu$m.
- Their vapor term alone gives the measured rate.
- The last column switches off the coupling to grain-boundary diffusion ($K_2 = K_m$). With their parameters $A = 3.5 \times 10^8$, and the coupling raises the driving curvature $K_2$ by a factor of about 4000.

**Check and its limit.** Their Figure 10 (25 $\mu$m, $T/T_m = 0.8$) was recomputed. The vapor current agrees ($2 \times 10^{-21}$ rising to $3 \times 10^{-20}$ m$^3$ s$^{-1}$; theirs about $10^{-21}$ to $2 \times 10^{-20}$). The surface current starts about 100 times above theirs, because they solve the four coupled equations iteratively where this uses the approximate Eq. (20). The table therefore *overstates* surface diffusion. Script and output: `studies/molaro_2019/sa81_mechanisms/`.

**What it implies.** The gap is between our vapor route ($\alpha_c = 0.1$, diffusion through air) and whatever supplies vapor in the experiment. A one-equation neck model fitted to the same data wants $\alpha_c \approx 0.3$–1 (`studies/molaro_2019/envelope_ode/`).

## B. The saturated pair against the Gibbs–Thomson law

**Question.** Is the exponent of 0.21 physics or resolution?

**Prediction.** For a neck of radius $x$ between grains of radius $R$, with fillet radius $\rho = x^2/(2(R-x))$, fed from the grain surface through attachment in series with gas diffusion over a length $c\rho$:

$$v_n = \frac{d_0 \left( \dfrac{1}{\rho} - \dfrac{1}{x} + \dfrac{2}{R} \right)}{\beta_{\mathrm{sub}} + c\,\rho\,k_D}, \qquad \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\mathrm{d}t} = \frac{\pi}{2}\, v_n, \qquad k_D = \frac{\rho_{\mathrm{ice}}}{D_v\, \rho_{vs}^I}.$$

Attachment alone gives $x^3 \propto t$; diffusion alone $x^5 \propto t$. $R = 84.4$ $\mu$m, $-20$ °C, $\alpha_c = 10^{-3}$; $c = 0.275$ from the Molaro run, not refitted. Here gas diffusion is 0.4–2% of the resistance. Integrated from the run's first sample after relaxation, it gives a final width of 60.6 $\mu$m (run: 63.2) and an exponent of 0.29 (run: 0.21).

**Run against prediction** ($\varepsilon = 0.12$ $\mu$m; one interface band $= 9.19\,\varepsilon = 1.1$ $\mu$m; exponents from fits of $C(t + t_0)^a$ starting at the time shown):

| Start | $w$ [$\mu$m] | $w/\varepsilon$ | fillet [bands] | velocity, run / prediction | $a$, run | $a$, prediction |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 2 h | 35.1 | 293 | 2.1 | 2.54 | 0.215 | 0.292 |
| 6 h | 39.2 | 327 | 2.7 | 1.72 | 0.221 | 0.292 |
| 16 h | 44.9 | 374 | 3.7 | 1.36 | 0.227 | 0.290 |
| 31 h | 50.1 | 418 | 4.8 | 1.18 | 0.231 | 0.288 |
| 51 h | 55.0 | 459 | 6.0 | 1.08 | 0.234 | 0.287 |
| 71 h | 58.8 | 490 | 7.1 | 1.02 | 0.236 | 0.286 |

The excess fits $1 + 11.4\,(\text{band}/\text{fillet})^{2.7}$ (rms 0.035).

**Sensitivity to the assumed contact time** (same data, $t_0$ fixed):

| $t_0$ | 4.8 h (free fit) | 8 h | 12 h | 16 h | 24 h |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| exponent | 0.212 | 0.234 | 0.258 | 0.281 | 0.325 |
| rms misfit | 0.28% | 0.78% | 1.33% | 1.73% | 2.31% |

The prediction takes 16 h to grow a neck to the run's first fitted width.

**What it shows and what it does not.** The rate converges on the sharp-interface law, and the early excess accounts for most of the difference in exponent. Two causes fit these numbers equally: the interface being too wide for a small fillet, or the pre-made neck relaxing from its imposed shape. The August run from tangent contact, at twice this interface width, showed no excess and gave 0.283, which points to the pre-made neck. The pending run from contact at this interface width tests it directly. Neither shows the predicted exponent being reached within 100 h from a pre-made neck (0.236 at the end against 0.29). Scripts and output: `studies/molaro_2019/demmenie/` (`predict_neck_growth.py`, `interface_width_estimate.py`).

### C. What the appendices of the manuscript should hold

The draft now has two appendix headings with these titles. Suggested content, each under a page:

- *Appendix A, Surface diffusion against vapor transport:* the two rate equations and the curvature relations, the parameter list, the four-row table, and the two sentences on what was and was not reproduced of Molaro's Figure 10.
- *Appendix B, The saturated pair against the Gibbs–Thomson law:* the neck law, the run-against-prediction table, the contact-time table, and the result of the tangent-start run.
- The time–temperature scaling (two pages, in `temperature_scaling/`) is a candidate third appendix, or supporting information, for Section 5.2.

## Citations: what the .bib lacks

Suggested above and present in the `.bib`: all of them. Mentioned in this plan and *not* in the `.bib`:

- Auriault, Boutin & Geindreau (2009), the book whose naming of **t** the paper follows (doi:10.1002/9780470612033).
- Ettrich et al. (2014), the tensor law applied to heat conduction; only if a second reference for the law is wanted.
- A source for packing and percolation thresholds of discs, if Section 5.3 states them.

- Classical neck-growth exponents (Introduction paragraph 4, Figure 4): Kuczynski (1949), Kingery & Berg (1955), Hobbs & Mason (1964). None is in the `.bib`; the $t^{1/3}$ curve in Figure 4 needs one of them.

Two keys are still in the old style in the `.bib` itself: `choukroun_strength_2020` and `nicoli_tensorial_2011`.

## Corrections that recur throughout

Paragraph-specific corrections are under each paragraph. These apply everywhere:

- **Notation.** Subscripts "ice" and "air" in place of $i$ and $a$ ($\rho_{\text{ice}}$, $\phi_{\text{ice}}$, $\phi_{\text{air}}$); $\mathbf{K}_{\text{eff}}$ for the tensor and $k_{\text{eff}}$ for its scalar mean; $k_{\text{ice}}$, $k_{\text{air}}$ as in the tables (the text has $K_{\text{ice}}$); $\rho_{\text{air}}$, $P_{\text{atm}}$ in Eq. (2); $\phi$ against $\phi_i$ for the same field in Section 2.3.
- **Temperature.** Celsius with $T + T_0$ in Eqs. (3), (5); kelvin in Eq. (7) and Table 1. One convention.
- $\varepsilon$ is the interface parameter, not the interface width (L192, L271).
- **"effect"** for "affect" (six places); "preform" for "perform" (three); doubled words where `\cref` already prints the word ("table table", "figure figure", "section section").
- $\alpha_c$ written $1.002 \times 10^{-3}$, not "1.002e-03".
- **Not cited in the text:** Table 2, Table 3, Figure 2.